Cosanie Mortaba Derogongan

Cosanie Mortaba Derogongan (DSc, MPA) is a Filipino peace architect and the current Director of the **Bureau of Peace and Conflict Resolution (BPCR)** at the **National Commission on Muslim Filipinos (NCMF)**. A member of the Meranao people from Lanao, he is recognized for his unique ability to bridge hard-edged security expertise with culturally grounded peacebuilding. After spending over two decades as a disciplining authority in the Philippine National Police system, Derogongan pivoted to become one of the country's leading mediators in the Bangsamoro region, pioneering frameworks that address rido (clan feuds) and prevent violent extremism. He's known for translating complex peace concepts into practical tools that speak the language of communities on the ground, earning him the title of "Institutional State-Builder" and making him the architect behind peace initiatives that actually stick.

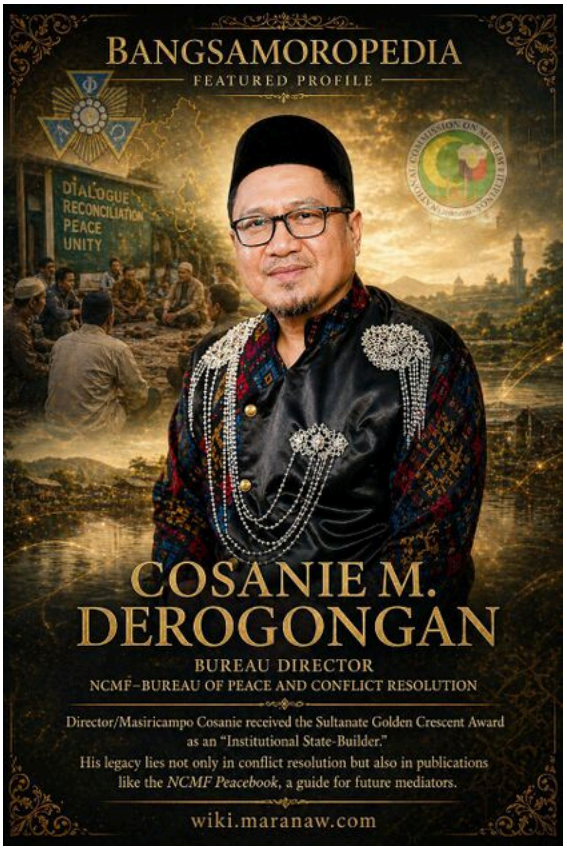
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Background and Identity

Cosanie Mortaba Derogongan belongs to the **Meranao** people, traditionally known as the "People of the Lake" from the Lanao region of Mindanao. This cultural identity isn't just background detail—it's the foundation of his entire approach to peacebuilding. Growing up in a society where honor codes, lineage systems, and Islamic faith form the backbone of social organization, he developed an intimate understanding of how traditional structures intersect with modern governance.

Cosanie Mortaba Derogongan



Bureau Director	Bureau of Peace and Conflict Resolution
Commission	National Commission on Muslim Filipinos
Born	Lanao region, Mindanao, Philippines
Ethnicity	Meranao
Education	Director Staff Course Master of Public Administration (MPA)
Occupation	Peace architect, conflict mediator, former disciplining authority
Known for	Rido conflict resolution Bangsamoro peace process Counter-violent extremism leadership 7 F's of Peacebuilding framework
Awards	Sultanate Golden Crescent Award (2025)

He maintains strong ties to the **Sultanate of Phangampong a Pilipinas**, a connection that gives him what insiders call "cultural currency"—the kind of legitimacy that can't be earned through government credentials alone. In communities where traditional authority still carries more weight than official titles, this affiliation has proven invaluable in his mediation work. It allows him to navigate the complex social webs of Mindanao's traditional power structures while representing state interests.

His Meranao identity also shapes his understanding of **rido**—the traditional system of clan-based blood feuds that can spiral from personal disputes into regional conflicts. Having grown up within these social dynamics, Derogongan doesn't approach rido as an outsider trying to impose solutions, but as someone who understands the underlying logic of honor, shame, and kinship that drives these conflicts.

Education

Derogongan's academic credentials reflect his commitment to backing cultural intuition with rigorous study. He holds a **Master of Public Administration (MPA)**, which gave him the technical foundation in governance, administrative law, and policy implementation. This degree was critical during his years working within the Philippine bureaucracy, where understanding the machinery of government was essential.

He later earned a **Director Staff Course**, a degree offered by the **Philippine Public Safety College** that bridges social work, community intervention, and ethical frameworks for social change. This combination of "hard" administrative training and "soft" social science created a unique skill set—he could operate fluently in both the world of government regulations and the world of community-based conflict resolution.

His academic work also influenced his writing style. Unlike many bureaucrats who speak in impenetrable jargon, Derogongan developed a talent for translating technical concepts into accessible frameworks. This ability would later define his most influential contributions, from policy documents to grassroots training materials.

Career

The Disciplinarian Phase: DILG and NAPOLCOM

Before becoming known as a peacebuilder, Cosanie Mortaba Derogongan spent over 20 years in what he would later describe as the "lion's den" of Philippine internal security. Working within the **Department of the Interior and Local Government (DILG)** and the **National Police Commission (NAPOLCOM)**, he served as a disciplining authority—essentially the person responsible for making sure police officers followed the rules.

This wasn't a desk job. It involved investigating misconduct, adjudicating cases, and enforcing ethical standards in one of the country's most challenging institutions. The work required a deep understanding of law enforcement culture, administrative procedures, and the delicate balance between discipline and institutional loyalty. It was a career defined by strict adherence to the law and what Derogongan calls the "hard side" of state power.

The experience gave him something invaluable for his later work: credibility with security forces. When he eventually transitioned to peacebuilding, he could speak the language of generals and police chiefs because he had been one of them. He understood the security mindset, the institutional pressures, and the practical constraints that military and police leaders face when dealing with conflict zones.

This phase also taught him about the limits of pure enforcement. No matter how many disciplinary cases he resolved, no matter how many rules were tightened, the problems kept recurring. It planted the seed for what would become his life's work: the realization that lasting stability couldn't be imposed from above—it had to be built from

within communities.

The Pivot to Peace: NCMF and Bureau of Peace and Conflict Resolution

When Derogongan moved to the **National Commission on Muslim Filipinos (NCMF)**, he essentially "re-coded" everything he had learned about security and law enforcement for a completely different mission: peacebuilding. As the Director of the **Bureau of Peace and Conflict Resolution (BPCR)**, he became the commission's point person for some of the most intractable conflicts in Mindanao.

His role in the **Bangsamoro peace process** positioned him as a technical bridge between national government agencies and local communities. While high-level peace talks grabbed headlines, Derogongan was doing the unglamorous but critical work of translating agreements into community-level implementation. He helped design the mechanisms that would allow transitional governance to function, working with traditional leaders to ensure that peace frameworks respected local customs while meeting constitutional requirements.

One of his signature achievements has been his work on **rido resolution**. Unlike purely academic experts who study clan feuds from a distance, Derogongan developed practical intervention models that could be deployed in real-time conflicts. He trained mediators, created resolution protocols that incorporated Islamic law and customary practices, and built networks of local peacemakers who could respond before disputes escalated into violence.

In the realm of **counter-violent extremism**, he took on leadership of the **Religious Leaders Cluster** under the **National Action Plan on Preventing and Countering Violent Extremism (NAP-PCVE)**. Rather than treating radicalization as purely a security problem, Derogongan approached it as a crisis of faith and community. His strategy focused on strengthening religious leadership, building community resilience, and addressing the grievances that make extremist narratives attractive. It was a long game, focused on prevention rather than reaction.

Institutional Contributions and Frameworks

What distinguishes Derogongan from other peace practitioners is his ability to distill complex peacebuilding concepts into frameworks that ordinary people can grasp and use. He doesn't just mediate conflicts—he builds systems that allow others to become mediators.

The 7 F's of Peacebuilding

Inspired by the Quranic story of **Ashab al-Kahf** (The People of the Cave), Derogongan developed what he calls the **7 F's of Peacebuilding**—a framework that has been adopted across NCMF programs and beyond:

- **Faith**: The spiritual foundation that serves as a shield against extremist ideologies. Derogongan argues that genuine faith creates ethical boundaries that violence can't cross.
- **Fajr (Discipline)**: Named after the dawn prayer, this represents the discipline of early rising and God-consciousness. It's about building daily habits that reinforce commitment to peace.
- **Forgiveness**: The only mechanism that can break the cycle of vengeance. In rido contexts, this is the hardest principle to apply but the most transformative when achieved.
- **Fasting**: Beyond the religious practice, this represents building patience, self-control, and the ability to endure hardship without resorting to violence.

- **Family**: The primary unit that must be protected from division. Derogongan sees family cohesion as the first line of defense against both extremism and feuding.
- **Fulfillment**: Finding contentment and purpose to avoid the lure of criminal enterprise or armed conflict. This addresses the economic and psychological drivers of violence.
- **Fellowship**: Building community ties that transcend clan boundaries. Strong inter-clan relationships make rido less likely and easier to resolve when it occurs.

The 5 M's for a Peaceful Life

Alongside the 7 F's, Derogongan teaches a personal discipline framework called the **5 M's for a Peaceful Life**, focused on individual self-control:

- **Mouth**: Guarding speech, avoiding gossip, slander, and inflammatory language that can trigger conflicts.
- **Mind**: Cultivating pure intentions and examining the motivations behind actions.
- **Mood**: Managing emotions, especially anger, through patience and reflection.
- **Manner**: Reflecting ethical character in all interactions, treating others with dignity regardless of status.
- **Money**: Using wealth responsibly, avoiding corruption, and practicing moderation.

These frameworks aren't just theoretical. They're embedded in NCMF training programs, peace education curricula, and community workshops throughout Mindanao. The genius is in their simplicity—they're easy to remember, culturally resonant, and actionable.

Publications and Thought Leadership

Derogongan has established himself as one of the leading voices on conflict resolution in Muslim Mindanao through both policy documents and public scholarship. His most significant work is **The Rido Conflict: Origins, Challenges, and Paths to Peace**, a comprehensive analysis that combines historical research, case studies, and practical resolution strategies. The book has become required reading for mediators, local officials, and anyone serious about understanding clan feuds in the region.

Beyond individual publications, he has been the driving force behind the **NCMF Peacebook**, a regularly updated manual that serves as the commission's institutional knowledge base for conflict resolution. It compiles best practices, case studies, mediation protocols, and training materials—essentially everything a new mediator needs to know. The Peacebook represents Derogongan's commitment to institutionalizing peace work so that it doesn't depend on individual personalities but becomes embedded in systems.

His writing style is distinctive. Unlike the dense academic prose that dominates peace studies, Derogongan writes in a way that's accessible without being simplistic. He uses stories, metaphors drawn from Islamic tradition, and concrete examples rather than abstract theory. This makes his work useful not just to scholars but to the grassroots mediators who do the actual work of peace.

Legacy and Recognition

In 2025, Cosanie Mortaba Derogongan received the **Sultanate Golden Crescent Award** in recognition of his contributions as an "Institutional State-Builder." The award acknowledged not just his individual mediation successes but his larger impact on creating the systems and frameworks that allow peace work to scale and endure.

His legacy extends beyond the specific conflicts he has resolved. He has trained a generation of mediators who carry forward his methods. He has created frameworks that have been adopted by multiple government agencies and civil society organizations. He has built bridges between traditional and modern governance structures, between security forces and peace advocates, between Islamic scholarship and government policy.

What makes Derogongan's contribution particularly significant is the model he represents for Filipino Muslim leadership. In a political landscape where Muslim Filipinos are often marginalized or stereotyped, he demonstrates a different kind of power—one based on cultural authenticity, intellectual rigor, and practical impact rather than electoral politics or armed struggle. He proves that you can be deeply rooted in traditional Islamic and Meranao identity while also being a sophisticated, effective state institution builder.

Personal Philosophy

At the core of Derogongan's work is a simple but profound belief: you can't have security without peace, and you can't have peace without a deep, respectful understanding of culture and faith. This philosophy emerged from watching security-first approaches fail repeatedly. He saw that military operations might suppress violence temporarily, but they couldn't address the underlying grievances, honor codes, and social dynamics that generated conflict in the first place.

His move from discipline to reconciliation wasn't a rejection of his security background but an evolution. He still believes in accountability, in rules, in the importance of strong institutions. But he learned that the most effective discipline isn't punishment—it's teaching people how to reconcile, how to forgive, how to find contentment without resorting to violence.

This is why his frameworks always integrate faith. For Derogongan, Islam isn't just a cultural identifier or a source of metaphors—it's the ethical foundation that makes peace sustainable. He believes that when communities are rooted in genuine spiritual practice, they develop the internal resources to resist both extremism and feuding. The 7 F's and 5 M's aren't secular peace techniques dressed up in religious language; they're arguments that the path to peace runs through the heart of faith itself.

See Also

- National Commission on Muslim Filipinos
- Bangsamoro peace process
- Rido
- Meranao people
- Preventing and Countering Violent Extremism (PCVE)
- Sultanate of Phangampong a Pilipinas

External Links

- [Official NCMF website]
- [Bureau of Peace and Conflict Resolution]

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